Rethinking hedging: towards a definition appropriate for Latin America

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2/11/26

Literature review

From balancing and bandwagoning to hedging

Alignment theory has traditionally offered weaker states two broad options when confronted with a stronger or rising power. Balancing involves building capabilities or forming coalitions against the most powerful (Waltz, 1979) or the most threatening actor (Walt, 1987). Bandwagoning involves aligning with the dominant or threatening power to avoid conflict or to gain benefits (Schweller, 1994). In Walt's formulation, threat is a function of aggregate power, geographic proximity, offensive capability and perceived intentions, and it is the perception of threat that drives both responses. Hedging entered the international relations vocabulary in the post-Cold War period to describe behaviour that fitted neither category, a middle position combining selective engagement, limited resistance and partial deference (Kuik, 2021). Early formulations by Medeiros (2005), Roy (2005) and Goh (2005) responded to the way Southeast Asian states related to a rising China while relying on the United States.

Enthusiasm for the concept outran its clarity. Haacke (2019) shows that scholars use the term in at least four different ways and that they disagree about which countries hedge. Only Singapore is consistently classified as a hedger across the leading studies, and Haacke himself concludes that Singapore balances. Ciorciari & Haacke (2019) and Jones & Jenne (2021) reach a similar diagnosis, with the latter describing hedging as a vague concept that has become a residual category of foreign policy behaviour.

Four families of definitions

Following Haacke (2019), the definitions can be grouped into four families. The first treats hedging as a response to risks arising from specific vulnerabilities, above all in energy and economic security (Tessman & Wolfe, 2011; Tunsjø, 2013). The second sees it as an alignment choice made in the face of a security challenge from a rising power (Goh, 2005; Roy, 2005). The third understands it as a way of managing the risks of alignment itself (Ciorciari, 2007; 2010; Koga, 2018; Lim & Cooper, 2015). The fourth defines it as a mixed policy approach that combines opposing behaviours (Chen & Yang, 2013; Kuik, 2016; Medeiros, 2005).

The families differ most in what they take to be the object of hedging. For Goh, hedging combines engagement of the rising power with the facilitation of a continuing US strategic presence as an indirect balance, so that the source of the security challenge and the source of insurance are distinct actors (Goh, 2005; 2006; 2007). Ciorciari's concept of limited alignment moves the focus from the challenger to the patron. Weaker states seek the security benefits of cooperation with a great power while avoiding commitments that carry costs, such as permanent basing, support for its military operations or adherence to its foreign policy positions (Ciorciari, 2007; 2010). In this account the risks being hedged are those created by alignment itself, notably loss of autonomy, entrapment and the provocation of the patron's rivals. Lim and Cooper place the emphasis on ambiguity. Hedging lies in the deliberate avoidance of a clear alignment with either power, which keeps options open (Lim & Cooper, 2015). Kuik conceives hedging as a combination of opposing behaviours, ranging from acceptance of a power's preferences (economic pragmatism, binding engagement and limited bandwagoning) to their rejection (dominance denial and indirect balancing), pursued under uncertainty and typically without public declaration (Kuik, 2008; 2016).

Kuik (2021) widens the concept beyond a response to China in three ways. First, he defines hedging as insurance-seeking behaviour under high uncertainty and high stakes in which the object of uncertainty is not only the principal threat but also the principal support, that is, whether a patron will remain reliable. Hedging is then driven by doubts about the credibility of the great powers on both sides. This is why Southeast Asian states hedged as US commitment oscillated between administrations and Chinese conduct shifted from charm to assertiveness. Second, hedging is not confined to weaker states in Southeast Asia. Japan, South Korea and India have hedged, and so have European states such as Germany and France in their China and Indo-Pacific policies, even though they are US allies or partners. Hedging can therefore be conducted by states formally tied to the dominant power. Third, hedging is better understood as instinctive behaviour than as a calculated grand strategy.

These broad formulations are the target of Haacke's critique. In his view the literature has treated hedging as a quasi-grand strategy, a mixed policy or an alignment posture, and it has largely avoided the question of how hedging can be identified empirically. Because almost any state that trades with one great power and cooperates militarily with another can be described in these terms, the concept risks over-diagnosing hedging and losing its analytical value.

Haacke's risk-based reformulation

Haacke (2019) proposes to restore the original connection between hedging and risk. Hedging is a risk management strategy, whereas balancing and bandwagoning are responses to threat. Risk is probabilistic, a function of likelihood and expected harm, and its management is anticipatory and proactive, whereas threats are associated with action-reaction dynamics. The distinction follows a standard risk-management cycle of identification, assessment, mitigation or acceptance, and re-evaluation. Hedging may take the form of self-help, engagement with the actor perceived as a risk, or the engagement of third parties, but engagement counts only if it is designed to mitigate the perceived risk. A risk can also be re-evaluated as a threat, a transition Haacke links to securitisation, which may occur among elites alone.

To identify hedging empirically he proposes three indicators. The first is official discourse, which shows whether a challenge is treated as a risk or as an acknowledged threat in the here and now. The second is the nature and purpose of military capabilities enhancement measures, following Liff (2016), where hedging is associated with normal surveillance and limited interoperability and balancing with build-up and threat-based exercises. The third is ambiguity in alignment signals, building on Lim and Cooper, so that a government that makes one great power its singular fall-back is balancing and not hedging. Applied to the South China Sea, the framework retains Malaysia as a hedger and reclassifies Singapore as a balancer.

The effectiveness of hedging and the room to hedge

A parallel strand asks whether hedging works and how long it can last. Ciorciari (2019) treats effectiveness as variable rather than assumed. Korolev (2019) argues that the room for hedging depends on both systemic pressures and unit-level features and that it narrows as great-power rivalry intensifies. Kuik (2021) makes the same point and adds two further elements. The extent of hedging depends on the availability of credible and reliable powers able to supply alternative public and private goods. Hedging ends when uncertainty is resolved, either in bandwagoning with the rising power if the patron withdraws, or in balancing if the threat becomes across-the-board. Geeraerts & Salman (2016) link hedging capability to economic, military and decision-making capacity and find that weakness on any dimension reduces it. Together these works suggest four determinants of effectiveness, namely alternative providers, the intensity of rivalry, the patron's tolerance of ambiguity and state capacity. They also imply a distinction between hedging as intended behaviour and hedging as achieved insurance, which most classifications conflate.

Alignment under regime insecurity

A separate tradition in the study of the Global South argues that alignment is shaped less by systemic threats than by the survival needs of leaders. David (1991)'s omnibalancing holds that leaders balance against both internal and external threats and align with the power that best protects their regime, even at the expense of state interests. Ayoob (1995) stresses that the security concerns of weak states are primarily internal and regional, Labs (1992) asks whether and why weak states bandwagon, and Schweller (1994) shows that alignment with a stronger power can be driven by opportunity as much as by fear. More recent work on political leaders and alignment extends this logic (Spektor & Fasolin, 2018). Kuik (2021) himself notes that elites are primarily concerned with domestic survival and that external relations are valued for what they deliver for legitimacy at home. In Africa, Vigne & Van Hoeymissen (2026) show how elite concerns over regime survival, territorial integrity and access to benefits shape the DRC's movement between hedging and constrained bandwagoning, and Whitaker (2010) tests soft balancing against the United States among African states, finding mixed results and noting the difficulty of distinguishing intentional balancing from routine resistance. For classification, this literature implies that behaviour resembling hedging may be regime-protective accommodation or opportunism, and that the relevant unit of analysis is often a government and not a state.

Hedging in Latin America

Applications to Latin America are recent. Cook et al. (2024) examine Brazil's strategies towards Sino-US competition, Adins (2026) examines strategic autonomy and hedging in Brazil, and Sims & Lee (2025) build a region-wide index from trade and arms-transfer shares, finding that only a handful of states hedge and that US dominance of the arms market creates a hegemonic ceiling. These studies mostly import the Southeast Asian frame of US-China competition and measure hedging as balanced exposure to the two powers. The region also has its own vocabulary for strategies towards a hegemon, notably relational autonomy (Russell & Tokatlian, 2003), autonomy through diversification (Vigevani & Cepaluni, 2007) and active non-alignment (Fortin et al., 2023), all framed against the structure of US hierarchy (Lake, 2009). Sims and Lee themselves present hedging as a measurement-oriented gloss on these traditions. Two questions therefore remain open. The first is whether the Southeast Asian definitions transfer to a hierarchical order in which the hegemon is also the main security provider. The second is what the concept of hedging adds to the autonomy tradition.

Transferability audit

Because the families rest on different assumptions, the question is not whether hedging travels but which definitions travel and under what conditions. Three conditions matter. The first is the identity of the risk source. The second is whether an insurer or alternative provider exists that can offset the risk. The third is whether the behaviour can be told apart from interest-driven diversification.

Family	Core logic	Risk source and insurer	Transfers to Latin America?
Risk from specific vulnerabilities	Diversify exposure to a named vulnerability	Can be economic or financial, insurer not required	Yes, if economic security counts and timing separates it from trade policy
Alignment choice facing a security challenge	Engage the challenger, rely on a distinct power as counterweight	Risk source and insurer must differ	Only where they differ, for example risks from a neighbour
Managing the risks of alignment	Gain patron benefits while limiting costs of commitment	Patron is both benefit and risk	Yes, most readily
Mixed policy approach	Combine opposing behaviours	Not specified	Yes, but residual and weakly discriminating

Risk from specific vulnerabilities

In the work of Tunsjø (2013) and Tessman & Wolfe (2011), hedging responds to a specific exposure, such as dependence on vulnerable energy supplies and sea lanes, and takes the form of diversifying suppliers, routes and capabilities. The logic transfers readily to Latin America because the region's exposure to both the hegemon and China can be itemised in the same way. Exposure to US instruments includes market access (tariffs), sanctions and visa restrictions on officials, financial dependence, and aid and security cooperation made contingent on reducing Chinese presence (The White House, 2025). Exposure to China includes concentrated export markets, project finance and critical digital infrastructure. US tariffs on Brazil (EL PAÍS, 2025) illustrate the first kind of exposure. Uruguay's bid to join RCEP (Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership) and its interest in the EU-Mercosur agreement, in a context where China buys roughly a quarter of its goods exports (Chu, 2026; Uruguay XXI, 2026), and Costa Rica's 5G regulation that excluded Huawei (Reuters, 2023), illustrate mitigation of the second. The family has a weakness in this context. Haacke requires that engagement be designed to mitigate a perceived security risk, while market diversification can equally be explained by commercial pragmatism. Uruguay's interest in Asian markets, for example, predates the current US pressure (Chu, 2026). The family therefore transfers if economic security is accepted as security and if timing and targeting are used to separate risk management from ordinary trade policy.

Alignment choice facing a security challenge

Goh's and Roy's formulation presupposes a rising power whose behaviour poses a security challenge and a distinct power whose presence offsets it. Venezuela does not fit. The January 2026 US operation that removed Nicolás Maduro (Elliott et al., 2026) was not an alignment choice facing a security challenge. The risk had already materialised into coercion, and the arrangements that followed were imposed rather than chosen. Venezuela is better treated as the end point of the risk-threat sequence in Haacke's framework, and as evidence on effectiveness, since its ties with Russia and China do not appear to have protected it. Its analytical value for the hedging debate lies in the demonstration effect on other governments, whose risk perceptions may have been revised upwards, as statements by Brazilian officials after the operation suggest (Amado Mundo, 2026; Gielow, 2026). The Goh configuration appears in Latin America mainly where the risk source is a neighbour and not a great power. Guyana's dispute with Venezuela over the Essequibo region and its security cooperation with the United States [add source] is the closest case, combining economic engagement with China with reliance on Washington. The general lesson is that the family transfers only when risk source and insurer are different actors, a condition that does not hold in the hegemonic relationship discussed below.

Managing the risks of alignment itself

In this family, associated with Ciorciari's limited alignment, Lim and Cooper's ambiguity and Koga's account of hedging under power shifts, the object of hedging is not the rising power but the consequences of committing to any power, including a protector. Weaker states want the benefits of a relationship without the costs that come with it. Those costs can be grouped into five types, each with a Latin American counterpart.

1. Entrapment and provocation, meaning being drawn into the patron's confrontations or being treated as a target by its rivals. The call by two former Chilean presidents for Chile to reconsider joining the Shield of the Americas, on the grounds that it should not be forced to choose sides (Sanhueza, 2026), is a debate about this risk.
2. Loss of autonomy through conditionality, which the US National Security Strategy makes explicit by making alliances and aid contingent on winding down non-hemispheric influence (The White House, 2025).
3. Retaliation by the other pole, as when the Chinese embassy objected to Costa Rica's 5G rules (Reuters, 2023) or when China sanctioned a Paraguayan minister over Paraguay's ties with Taiwan (Lee & Blanchard, 2026).
4. Domestic and regional costs, such as Mercosur's common commercial policy constraining Uruguay's trade ambitions (Chu, 2026).
5. Unreliability of the patron, which is Kuik's uncertainty about principal support. The lifting of US sanctions on Paraguay's former president after pro-US policy decisions (Blair, 2025; Office of Foreign Assets Control, 2025) shows how support can be transactional and reversible.

Peru combines membership of the Shield of the Americas and purchases of US F-16s with joint operation of the Chancay port with China (Glatsky, 2026), which can be read as managing the risks of each alignment. This family is the most transferable because it requires no Chinese military threat and fits a hierarchical order in which the main risk of alignment is dependence on the patron. Its weakness is observability, since limited alignment, ideological preference and commercial pragmatism can produce similar behaviour.

Mixed policy approach

This family transfers readily and, for that reason, discriminates least. Any Latin American state that combines Chinese trade with US security cooperation qualifies, including those whose behaviour reflects ideology or commercial interest. Applications such as Sims & Lee (2025) operationalise a version of it through balanced exposure in trade and arms, which cannot separate risk-driven from interest-driven diversification.

In sum, the first and third families transfer under conditions, the fourth transfers but is residual, and the second transfers only where the risk source and the insurer are different actors.

The structural inversion

Southeast Asian hedging is typically described in a structure where the risk source (China) and the insurer (the United States) are distinct, so that engagement with one offsets exposure to the other. In Latin America the hegemon is at once the principal security provider and, for governments that fear sanctions, tariffs or intervention, the principal source of coercive risk (Lake, 2009; The White House, 2025). This inversion has four consequences.

First, ambiguity, Haacke's third indicator, changes meaning. Ambiguity about future alignment is addressed to the same actor that is perceived as a risk, which makes it a more dangerous signal. Kuik (2021) observes that hedging is implemented without pronouncement because announcing it invites pushback, and the 2025 US strategy presents the choice as one between an American-

led order and one influenced by distant powers (The White House, 2025), which raises the cost of ambiguity.

Second, the mitigation toolkit shifts. China and Russia cannot offset US military coercion, so mitigation is mostly economic, financial, diplomatic and domestic. Sims and Lee report that more than 99 per cent of the region's major weapons between 2013 and 2023 came from the United States or allied suppliers, and they describe the purchase of major Chinese systems as a foreclosed option more than a strategic choice (Sims & Lee, 2025).

Third, engagement with the risk source can itself be mitigation. Haacke allows interactions with the actor perceived as a risk if they are designed to reduce it (Haacke, 2019). Joining US-led initiatives, accepting deportees or aligning on telecommunications may therefore be accommodation to reduce coercion risk and not ideological alignment or balancing against China. Distinguishing these requires attention to sequencing and to the regime-survival literature. Accommodation that follows explicit coercion, or that protects leaders from sanctions, looks different from alignment that precedes coercion and matches government ideology (David, 1991; Spektor & Fasolin, 2018). The relief of sanctions on Paraguay's former president after pro-US decisions needs this kind of scrutiny.

Fourth, effectiveness is limited, and this matters for the definitional debate. There are three limits. The first is offsetting capacity. Alternative providers cannot supply a security guarantee, which is precisely the condition Kuik (2021) identifies for hedging to work, and the Venezuelan case suggests that external partners did not shield the government from coercion (Elliott et al., 2026). The second is the hegemon's tolerance of ambiguity. When the hegemon treats hedging as hostility, the room to hedge shrinks in line with Korolev (2019). The third is capacity. Only states with strong institutions or resilient macroeconomic fundamentals appear able to sustain dual engagement (Geeraerts & Salman, 2016; Sims & Lee, 2025). Hedging may therefore be intended but ineffective, and an adequate approach must keep intended mitigation and achieved insurance apart (Ciorciari, 2019). States may also rationally accept risk, Haacke's alternative to mitigation, when mitigation is too costly.

Redefined indicators

Haacke's three indicators can be retained but must be re-specified for a hierarchical order in which the risk source is also the insurer, and complemented by tests that separate hedging from look-alike behaviour.

Indicator	What to observe	Rival explanation to rule out
Risk discourse	Official statements, defence strategies and UNGA speeches that identify specific US or Chinese instruments as risks to sovereignty, coded as risk (probabilistic, future) or threat (acknowledged, pre-	Signalling to Washington, or securitisation imported from the hegemon

Indicator	What to observe	Rival explanation to rule out
	sent). Compare statements to domestic and US audiences	
Risk-specific mitigation	Measures aimed at a named exposure and following the risk episode in time, such as financial buffers and swap lines, market diversification agreements, capability measures not directed at a named adversary, and legal or institutional commitments (Liff, 2016)	Commercial pragmatism, routine modernisation, fiscal motives
Ambiguity of alignment signals	Variation across signals in the same period, such as UN votes on contested resolutions, participation in US-led and alternative initiatives, telecommunications choices, and positions on the ICC and ICJ. The test is mixed signals, not their level	Uniform ideological alignment, regime-protective alignment, one-off signals
Sequencing and motive	Timing of accommodation relative to coercive episodes (tariffs, sanctions, visa revocations, conditional aid), government ideology and turnover, and leaders' exposure to sanctions or legal jeopardy (David, 1991)	Ideological or regime-protective alignment
Achieved effect	Change over time in market concentration, financial vulnerability and supplier concentration	Intended versus achieved insurance

These indicators allow six patterns to be distinguished.

Pattern	Risk discourse	Targeted mitigation	Signals
Hedging	Present	Present, multi-directional	Mixed

Pattern	Risk discourse	Targeted mitigation	Signals
Accommodation under coercion	Present	Via the risk source	Shift after coercion
Ideological alignment	Absent	Absent	Uniform
Regime-protective alignment	Variable	Variable	Follow the leader's exposure
Balancing or threat response	Acknowledged threat	Build-up, threat-based	Clear, with other poles
Risk acceptance	Present	Absent	Uniform or none

What to read next:

Articles

Ciorciari 2019

Korolev 2019

Cook et al.

Adins 2026

Books

Francisco Urdinez. Economic Displacement: China and the End of US Primacy in Latin America. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2026

Ekaterina Kosevich. Extra-Regional Powers in Latin America in the 21st Century: The Impact of the US, EU, China, and Russia

Elbridge A. Colby, The Strategy of Denial : American Defense in an Age of Great Power Conflict, Londres, Yale University Press, 2021.

Carlos Gustavo Poggio Teixeira, Brazil, the United States, and the South American Subsystem: Regional Politics and the Absent Empire

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